

BREECH-LOADING SHOTGUNS

In 1835, a French inventor named Casimir Lefauchaux made a breakthrough in sporting gun design with his patent for a pin-fire cartridge (see p. 112) and a gun with a break-open design (its barrels hinged downward for loading at the breech). Hinged barrels became almost universally adopted for sporting guns, although gunmakers created many designs for locking the breech. The pin-fire cartridge was eventually replaced by a center-fire cartridge (see pp. 112–13). Guns using pin-fire cartridges typically had distinctively long hammers that needed to strike down onto each cartridge's pin. The use of center-fire cartridges meant that a gun's hammers could be made smaller. Gunmakers also realized that the opening of the breech could be used to cock the gun, and "hammerless" shotguns began to appear before the end of the 19th century. Shotguns generally lacked sights, since they were fired by accurate pointing rather than deliberate aiming.

